Those horrible negative words, can't, won't, mustn't, couldn't, are at the forefront of the brain. Predictably, you get out, leaving your teammate, alarmed by the sudden shift in momentum, to struggle through the hardest period of any innings, the first ten to fifteen balls. He succumbs, and before you know it, you've lost three wickets in less than thirty minutes.

The collapse is on. The opposition have their tails up. Bowlers are running in harder, with greater intensity. The fielders are sharper, more eager. It's a hard task to shackle the game, stop it from sprinting away from you, especially in Test cricket, where the players are better, tougher, stronger. It's like a supercharged tug of war.

You can never win a Test match in a single session, but you can certainly go a long way towards losing one. A palpable air of tension descends on the dressing room. Later, in the debrief, you may conduct a thoughtful review, and suggest it might not have been the best policy to go quiet and retreat into your shells. Yet neither is it the time or the place for bluff and bluster.

The last thing you need, when you've gone from 50–0 to 50–3 in what feels like a heartbeat, is someone blathering on, in jolly-hockey-sticks mode. You need a partnership. You're desperate for that partnership. Yet something seems to be happening with every ball. It's like watching an avalanche start to roll down a mountain. This is something bigger than any of us.

There are plenty of England collapses that belong in cricket's dungeon. Six wickets lost for three runs presented Australia with a win at Melbourne in 1990. England lost their last eight wickets for twenty-six against Pakistan two years later, after Graham Gooch and Michael Atherton had scored 135 and 76, respectively. (Remarkably, they still somehow managed to win.)

We replaced New Zealand at the bottom of the world rankings by squandering our last eight wickets for thirty-nine against them at the Oval in 1999. Shane Warne seized the bragging rights when he was instrumental in England losing nine wickets for sixty at Adelaide in 2006. Oh, and in case you are wondering, regrets, I've had more than a few.

My team lost six wickets for nine runs in ten overs at Brisbane in 2013 and compounded the problem by losing our last seven batsmen for forty-nine in the second innings. We lost seven for forty-three in a defeat by South Africa at Centurion in 2016. We were 27–9 in the first Test of my last series in New Zealand, at Eden Park in Auckland in March 2018. That was so bad it was like an out-of-body experience.